
Investigating the Resilience of Waldensian Heterodoxy in Medieval Fribourg using Social Network Analysis

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Abstract

In 1430, Dominican inquisitors from Lausanne investigated the local community of Waldensians in the town of Fribourg (Utz Tremp, 2000). This community was unique in that, by 1430, it had not had regular contacts with Waldensian ministers for several decades, meaning that the surviving heterodox beliefs upheld by religious dissidents must have been perpetuated by common adherents. The register of interrogations conducted by the inquisitors – eleven of which subjected deponents to a standardised belief questionnaire – grants us insight into the variation in the beliefs of individual members of the Waldensian community as well as into interactions (belief spread, other communication, contact) among members of this network. Our study investigates whether patterns in the belief composition of members of the Waldensian network in Fribourg correlate with their topological characteristics. We are especially interested in examining whether individuals more active in communicating beliefs in this network had any unique belief attributes. This will provide insight into whether individuals of more defined canonical Waldensian beliefs held any special position (e.g., central) in the network, which might be interpreted as significant for spreading or maintaining such doctrines in a community without formal leadership.

We are using the modern scholarly edition of the inquisitorial register to collect available data on (1) suspects' attitudes to specific articles of Waldensian faith and (2) the interactions of different types each deponent was involved in. Specifically, this data is being collected using Computer-Assisted Semantic Text Modelling (CASTEMO), an approach that allows us to capture structured, quantifiable data on dissident beliefs and interactions while preserving contextual information and nuance from the source text (Zbírál et al., 2022; Shaw et al., 2026). We are also recording data on each individual's gender, kinship ties, quarter of residence, and, where available, profession and any public offices held. This part of the data collection is assisted by Kathrin Utz Tremp's detailed prosopographical study of the Fribourg Waldensians, *Waldenser, Wiedergänger, Hexen und Rebellen* (Utz Tremp, 1999). We then apply an Exponential Random Graph Model (ERGM) to study the distribution of the belief attributes among individuals in this network (Lusher et al., 2012).

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